club cricket together for Tukkies; I faced him in the nets on numerous occasions and he always caused me problems.

Back at Div Park, the odds were stacked against me.

He was 22, and I was 11. He was a tall, strong fast bowler playing senior club cricket in Johannesburg. I was a *laaitjie* playing barefoot at Warmbaths Primary School. We were playing on a kikuyu wicket measuring around 14 yards, rather than the usual 22 yards, and we were playing with a tennis ball, covered with insulation tape on one side, making it swing dramatically in both directions.

In fairness, Gerrit and the older boys did offer me one concession.

They said that, since I was so small and my bat was so heavy, as the bowler ran in, I was allowed to rest my bat on top of the rubbish bin that served as our stumps. It was a Duncan Fearnley bat handed down to me by Wessels, and it was three or four sizes too large, too heavy for me to lift and hold at the top of my backlift. More than 20 years later, there are a few echoes of this improvised backlift in my technique today.

I was ready. Focus, I told myself. Concentrate. Get into line. Fight. Don't give it away. Hit anything wide or short. Fight. Whatever you do, don't get out to the *oke* who trampled on your cap.

Gerrit ran in and bowled, again and again, but he couldn't get me out. It was well after sunset, and they couldn't get me out. Next my brother Jan came charging in off a 30-yard run with everyone else crowded around the bat, and they still couldn't get me out. I wanted to show them I was worthy of wearing the cap.

Fight. Get in line. Fight.

They started sledging. I ignored it. At one stage, while running a single, they physically blocked the middle of the wicket. Soon afterwards, I was actually lifted off my feet as I ran.

'That's not fair,' I protested. 'I'll tell Mom and Dad.'

'Do that and you'll never be allowed to play again,' came the reply.

No matter, I held my ground. I was fighting, loving every minute of